

ותמת שרה בקרית ארבע הוא: שרה אמנו begins with the passing of our beloved mother, חבורן בארץ פנעו ויבא אברהם לספד לשרה ולביתה. Those who pay attention will notice a small כ in the word ונסמכה מיתת שרה לעקדת יצחק לפי שעל ידי בשורת העקדה, וילביתה. רש"י comments on this, saying: פרחתה נשמתה ממנה ומתה. שרה אמנו heard the news that יצחק was nearly slaughtered, and from the shock of this revelation, she passed away.

The מדרש on this רש"י and the entire episode is vast. As many of us know, the שטן, representing the יצר הרע, tried everything to prevent the עקדה. The עקדה story is remarkable and has inspired many books, both religious and secular.

What's relevant here is that the שטן tried every possible tactic to prevent the עקדה. He appeared as a child, as an old man, and even transformed himself into a river, nearly drowning אברהם אבינו, who was up to his neck in water, calling out to Hashem to save him. All of these attempts by the שטן failed.

The עקדה was a success, and Baruch Hashem, we still discuss it to this day. What did the שטן do? He went to שרה and told her about the עקדה. According to different opinions, she died either from hearing that יצחק was going to be נשחט or from hearing that he wasn't נשחט. Regardless, the result is the same: שרה אמנו passed away.

I heard a דבר תורה from Rabbi Oelbaum, who attributes it to רב מאיר from פרמישלאן. As you all know, I often mention that my אלטע זיידע was a שוחט in פרמישלאן, whether it was at the time of רב מאיר from פרמישלאן or not is irrelevant, we have a deep connection to that holy city.

רב מאיר from פרמישלאן shared the following insight: The שטן failed to prevent the עקדה, so he took out his frustration by causing the death of שרה אמנו. What is this - sour grapes? He failed in his attempt, and now he takes it out on שרה?

He answers: every night we recite in השכיבנו: וְהָסֵר שָׁטָן מִלְּפָנֵינוּ וּמֵאַחֲרֵינוּ, which can be interpreted in numerous ways. One way is to teach us the concept of חרטה. When a person does תשובה, an essential component is חרטה, regret for the עבירה. If one regrets an עבירה, it almost entirely, if not completely, cancels out the עבירה. The famous מדרש says that חרטה chops off the legs of the מלאך created by the עבירה. So חרטה can erase עבירות.

But what is less known is that חרטה can also, G-d forbid, erase a מצוה. Imagine giving a quarter to someone at the shul in the morning. Later, you go to put a quarter in the parking meter, realize you don't have one, and regret giving it away. In that moment, you lose the מצוה, because you had חרטה on it. So we must be mindful of our thoughts.

שרה אמנו successfully completed the עקדה, to fulfill the dvar Hashem. Afterwards, the שטן came again, trying to cause חרטה in אברהם. The שטן wanted him to regret the עקדה by making him think it was the cause of שרה's death.



When אברהם came ולבכותה לשרה, he cried, but with a small כ - he didn't cry excessively. Why? To show he had no חרטה for the עקדה, even though it was a גורם for שרה's death. Once again, the שטן was defeated.

This teaches us to be extremely careful with our thoughts, as everything we do or think is accounted for. We must have tremendous כוונה and בטחון, especially now (written during the Gaza war), as all of us, our children, our soldiers, and civilians are facing threats. May we merit a tremendous ישועת Hashem, and may Hashem bless us with ברכה והצלחה. We should take seriously what we need to do in the future, as sometimes we may be too comfortable in גלות. I'm speaking to myself as well as to others; we all have room to improve in our mitzvos.

